

Today we take a look at "death".

Why is it so important to reflect about death?

We can distinguish between "organism" and "mechanism". The former is given by all beings, and are lead by natural intelligence, opposed to "mechanism", which works through artificial intelligence.

What "dasein" has in common with organism, and what with mechanism? With organism, we have in common the "bios", the fact that we exist. With mechanism, we share "logos".

Although dasein shares with organism the fact of having a biological life, that begins with birth and ends with death...

Likewise, although we share with mechanism the possibility of communication through language, our way of speaking is not that of the machines.

What is death according to Heidegger? We've seen that dasein is a *können sein*, a being able to be. He is a being in the possibility, rather than being in the necessity of being something.

Whereas organisms follows instinct, mechanism functions according to pre-determined algorithmic programs, human beings have the burden of throwing a project over themselves. As long as dasein is, *until the end of his days*, he has to deal with his being able to be, so to his freedom.

Philosophy has many definitions of freedom. Let's borrow the idea of freedom from the one of "space of playing". But how are these two connected? When we say that a door has a space for play, we mean that the door wobbles (?), or moves when closed, so some components are loosen, and so this situation prevents the door from fitting tightly into its frame.

Something has room for play when it has enough space to move smoothly.

In the same way, human beings are not rigidly fixed to a determining law and necessity. It is precisely in this "play", margin of movement, that freedom and our possibility of being reside.

We've seen that the totality of human possibilities in order to be fully realised must also include the extreme possibility, that is no longer being there, death.

No matter how many possibilities I've experienced, as long as my dasein is, there will always be one possibility missing, the last one. Yet, when dasein reaches the totality of its possibility through that, it entails its total loss.

In this sense, death is that experience that we can only experience, but we cannot have experience of it. Death is thus an experience that is inaccessible to the individual dasein, until it dies. That's why the death of the others is shocking for

us, who we are "mit sein". The death of others display us the end of dasein.

"Prima ci era un esserci, che ora non ci è più". "There was a dasein that now is no longer here". The longer being in the world characteristic of death, is still a mode of being in the world, but a defective one. What used to be a living dasein is now turned into a presence, a corporal thing encountered in the world among the others.

With the death of others, a specific phenomenon becomes experientable, the fading of dasein into a no longer being there. The end of dasein is the beginning of it become a "thing". Yet, this "thing" is not treated as such by those who remain. In the act of remaining with the corpse, in mourning and recollecting who the dead used to be, those who survive cannot experience the loss. We never genuinely experience the dying of others, in fact all we do is attending it, "ad-sistere". It actually has a double meaning: in the one hand it means to be present for and help, while we could attend a concert/class. So, where we're present in attending and involved, but as spectators, and not as actors.

Despite the closeness that we feel for the diseased, we remain external observers, and the loss experience by who's attending the death, is not comparable by the loss of who dies. In some case, among the possibilities of being with in the world, there is that of substitution: a dasein taking the place of one other. There are acts of heroism and love where we sacrifice ourselves in place of other. However, even these sacrifices does not take the death of other away, rather it postpones it.

As long as it's alive, the dasein carries within thhe possibility of being something. It contains a not yet that will, that is a constant lake of the totality of his possibilities.

Complete loss (???)

Reaching the end implies, for each respective dasein, a mode of being where substitution is not possible.

Dasein is thus characterised by a constant non-totality that only death can complete. Just like other ?, we're creatures thrown into time, and our existence enfolds through different forms and ages (childhood, adulthood). Just like an apple tree that was once just a seed, then grow up to be a tree. As long as we live, we're evolving not only physically, becoming something different.

We've already been something in the past, and we're projected towards what we're not yet. Can the not yet of an apple be equated with the not yet of the dasein?

For Heidegger, the answer is not. The fruit has not choosen what to become, what is not yet is not added as something externally ???

For us, things are different, our not yet is not merely provisional, but is something

that sometimes might be inaccessible even for ourselves, we don't know yet what we'll become, how the life experience will work on us.

got lost here

With maturation, the fruit is complete. Its purpose to become a juicy red apple is fulfilled, but is death a fulfillment for human beings in the same sense? With death, *dasein* completes its earthly course, but does it also complete his possibilities? Or are these possibilities rather taken away from him? We must therefore distinguish between coming to an end, the fulfillment of an apple, and ending, finishing. In fact, as we can observe, even an unfulfilled *dasein* ends. We may ask ourselves now when do we use this expression: to finish and come to an end. They may have different meanings. When we say it has finished raining, it indicates the dissolution is a known presence. But when we say the ally ends into the main road, it indicates reaching the full presence by its end.

In death, *dasein* is neither fulfilled, nor dissolved, nor completed, nor consumed. These meanings are to be applied for entities, but not for *dasein*. Let's consider the meaning which can be referred to the end of our existence.

Although we're always projected toward a not yet, at the same time we're always exposed to our no more, to the possibility that all our possibilities may cease and finish. This possibility is present since from the beginning of life, and through our lives it follows us. Death is a way of being that *dasein* assumes as soon as he comes into existence. As Heidegger says: as soon as a human being is born, he's already old enough to die.

Phenomenology can grasp the unseen starting from what appears, but cannot imagine what is not given. Even science, that deals with death by collecting data, will never be able to answer those ultimate question about the meaning of our end. All the issues examining do not pertain to our analysis, as they would need to presuppose

We consider ourselves individuals detached from the rest. However, if we're part of a renewing system where our death is not considered singularly, we should agree on the concept of evil and injustice.

What can be easily observed is that death is a phenomenon of life.

Phenomenologically, what matters is what death is rooted within *dasein*. We've seen how *dasein* is always in this exchange, always have to deal with his possibilities, including the not being. Being among the possibilities as the most certain and ine...

It is not something that is merely pending, rather an imminence that hangs over us. Many situations can threaten *dasein* in its being in the world, like a sudden

storm, but no one of these situations can be referred to the menace that death exercises on us.

In this case, what is imminent is *dasein* itself, its condition of being in the world. Death is the possibility of no longer being able to be in the world.

This possibility reveals itself in anguish. But Heidegger says that true anguish, the kind through which we're brought back to ourselves, is rare. The fact that most people know nothing about death, and try to remove it from thoughts and conversations, shows that *dasein* tends to cover over anguish that this condition generates.

Dasein, by taking refuge in things, seeks to escape the disorientation that death produces in us. Here, the dictatorship of *das man*, comes to the aid of *dasein*, offering opportunities for diversion from himself, the possibility of distancing itself from the possibility of coming into contact with true anguish. The understanding of death is entrusted in the superficiality of small talk, and the ambiguity of misunderstanding. Thanks to the covering functions, these two prevent ourselves of looking into death.

The dictatorship makes us see death as an event continuously happen to someone, who at certain point dies. Strangers die everyday and hour, and thus death is just another event in the world, flattened in something ordinary.

In such discourse, death is understood as something indetermined, which will certainly happen, but is not yet present and therefore does not threaten us.

The evasion of death by covering it over so stubbornly dominates everyday life that even the closest relatives, when attending to comfort the dying, telling that he will certainly escape death, returning to his peaceful life. This constant reassurance reveals a hidden terror. In the dictatorship of everyday being with, thinking about death is discouraged and regarded as coward fear, insecurity.

Das man does not allow *dasein* to approach authentic anguish, trivializing into fear. *Dasein* is expected an indifferent calm in the face of the fact that one day he'll die.

Repeating this kind of indifference do not strengthen *dasein*, nor does it truly reassure him, rather it alienates him from his authentic possibilities open through the experience of anguish. In its average everyday interpretation, death is something certain, but no one is certain about his own death. Postponing the finitude to a moment that *das man* conceals the characteristic of death, the possibility to die at any moment.

On one side we have the certainty of death, which is diluted in the indeterminacy of when, and this predisposes *dasein* in fleeing the anguish.

It is not possible to reach the certainty about death since it does not fall in the

domain of scientific truth. The only way to understand death as the possibility that is as the event that threatens us, and not as an eventuality that does not concern us, is to place ourselves in a state of anticipation, that is to attend it. On the one hand, to attend means to wait for, reach for the realisation of something, in the other hand means to be attentive to something. This allows to understand death authentically, by anticipating in thought we restore its proper weight, revealing as the possibility of impossibility of existings, therefore the necessity of renouncing to ourselves.

We've described dasein as a thrown project, and in this definition we emphasise the dual movement of existence: one of being thrown in the world, and the other the project that ourselves throw in the world.

This comes to an end when we die. Opening ourselves to the possibility of no longer being has a liberating effect, as it allows us to free, to get rid of our existential horizon of all those possibility that are not truly ours.

The anguish that withdraw us from the domination of others, distancing the world, thus represents the condition where dasein stops fleeing, and begins to project starting from the most authentic possibilities, and the most certain one, death.